RESEARCH • EVIDENCE • DESIGN • IMPLEMENTATION

The Reversibility Canvas

Calibrating Entrepreneurial Evidence to the Cost of Being Wrong

Research question
How much evidence should an entrepreneur require before acting on a particular assumption?

Fixed workflow
Decision → Critical Assumption → Reversibility Profile → Evidence Threshold → Exit Trigger

Status
Research prototype. All model percentages are illustrative and not empirically calibrated.

Olive & Oat source pack | 2 November 2026

PART 01 / RESEARCH FOUNDATION

The Reversibility Canvas

Calibrating Entrepreneurial Evidence to the Cost of Being Wrong

Research question. How much evidence should an entrepreneur require before acting on a particular assumption?

Status (2 November 2026). This document specifies the theoretical rationale and proposed evaluation of a research artefact. It does not report validated causal effects, empirically calibrated five-dimensional weights, or user-performance improvements.

1. Context and problem

Entrepreneurs routinely make decisions with incomplete, unevenly distributed and often indirect evidence. A customer interview may inform a pricing hypothesis, a pilot may demonstrate technical feasibility, and an early contract may establish willingness to pay. None of these observations automatically justifies the same level of commitment across different actions. Rewriting a landing page, placing a small inventory order, entering an exclusive multi-year supply agreement and deploying a regulated financial product expose an enterprise to different costs of revision, even when each rests on a proposition whose truth remains uncertain. The relevant managerial problem is therefore not simply whether an assumption has been tested, but whether available evidence is proportionate to the commitment that would be created by acting on it.

Entrepreneurial tools such as the Business Model Canvas, Lean Startup experimentation templates and hypothesis lists contribute to articulation, learning and business-model iteration, but their typical use does not impose an explicit, decision-specific relationship between the strength of supporting evidence and the cost of being wrong. The Reversibility Canvas addresses this unresolved design requirement as a proposed complement to existing tools. Its central unit is a bounded **commitment episode**, not an entire firm’s quality or its probability of survival. One venture may rationally conduct a six-week nonexclusive pilot and irrationally accept an otherwise comparable thirty-month exclusive arrangement because the two options expose the same weak assumption to different losses, lock-in and exit conditions.

2. Intellectual lineage and what it does not establish

Effectuation and affordable loss. Sarasvathy (2001) distinguished reasoning centred on controlling an uncertain future from reasoning centred on predicting it. The affordable-loss tradition directs attention to downside that an entrepreneur is prepared to accept. This supports defining a commitment’s possible loss and controllability; it does not itself establish a universal metric for evidence sufficiency. The Canvas extends this insight by relating the cost of committing to the quality and directness of evidence for the commitment’s critical premise.

Real options and staged investment. McGrath (1999) used real-options logic to reinterpret entrepreneurial failure and the conditions under which investment should continue. The economic value of waiting, experimenting and retaining a switch option depends on both learning and the cost of holding options open. The Canvas accordingly treats shorter commitments, break clauses, pilots and phased investment as design interventions capable of reducing evidentiary requirements without pretending that uncertainty has disappeared. A long delay can also destroy value: option preservation is not equivalent to indefinite inaction.

Entrepreneurial experimentation and evidentiary precision. Kerr, Nanda and Rhodes-Kropf (2014) explain entrepreneurship as an experimentation process shaped by experimentation costs and constraints. Camuffo, Cordova, Gambardella and Spina (2020) provide experimental evidence that teaching entrepreneurs a more scientific approach to testing hypotheses can improve decision precision and encourage appropriate pivots. These studies support serious attention to how evidence is generated and interpreted; they do not test the specific reversibility-contingent threshold rule of this Canvas. Thomke (1998) likewise shows that the modes and economics of experimentation matter, making over-testing a genuine design concern rather than an automatic virtue.

Escalation of commitment. Staw (1976) demonstrated that actors can increase resource commitment in the face of negative feedback, especially when personally responsible for prior decisions. A pre-specified Exit Trigger is a prospective mechanism for resisting post-hoc reinterpretation. However, written triggers may themselves be ignored or renegotiated in real teams; that behavioural effectiveness is an empirical question.

Design science and tool-specific knowledge. Hevner et al. (2004) situate artefact construction and evaluation at the centre of design-science research. Autio, Buyssens, Seckler and Thomas (2026) call for systematic inquiry into entrepreneurial tools and distinguish tools, workflows and generalisable design knowledge. The Reversibility Canvas therefore has two linked but separable objects of evaluation: the correctness and usability of a structured decision artefact, and the empirical effects of using it in entrepreneurial decision processes.

3. Novel design proposition

Proposed design principle. As the foreseeable cost and difficulty of reversing an entrepreneurial commitment increase, the evidentiary requirement for its critical assumption should normally become stronger, more direct and more triangulated, subject to the cost of further testing, the value of timely action and non-compensatory legal or stakeholder constraints.

The design is deliberately asymmetric. Both proceeding too early with a difficult-to-reverse commitment and over-testing a cheap, reversible experiment can destroy entrepreneurial value. The Canvas is not an algorithm of maximal caution. It asks users to distinguish *uncertainty that merits additional evidence* from *uncertainty that can be confronted by restructuring the commitment itself*. This distinction yields a potentially distinctive design mechanism: the tool may recommend a smaller test, a shorter contract, a narrower exclusivity provision or a specified exit clause, instead of requesting more evidence for an unchanged decision.

The novel **claim is a testable design proposition**, not an assertion that this principle has already been validated. Its distinctive prediction is that, under similar uncertainty, changing the commitment architecture should alter the appropriate evidence demand and the recommended action. If an existing generic

experimentation template produces the same calibration and commitment-restructuring behaviour, or if calibrated evidence thresholds do not improve decisions, the proposed incremental contribution would be reduced.

4. The five-step Canvas

01 Decision. Record the concrete action, decision owner, firm or team context, commitment amount, duration, alternatives and date. Output is a bounded commitment statement that another reviewer can identify independently of the founder's general ambition. An action such as 'expand internationally' is too broad; 'sign an exclusive 24-month distribution contract requiring a £150,000 minimum purchase' is assessable.

02 Critical Assumption. Specify the claim that must hold for the action to remain defensible, with observable indicators, relevant population and time horizon. Evidence must be time-stamped and linked to this particular claim. Pilot conversion among existing customers cannot be silently generalised to an unfamiliar region, segment or scale. Output is a falsifiable proposition and a register of known, disputed and unknown facts.

03 Reversibility Profile. Characterise financial exposure, time lost, contractual lock-in, operational dependencies, reputational harm, stakeholder consequences and resource redeployability. The dimensions describe different mechanisms of difficulty in undoing the action. They are not automatically summed into one universal risk score. Output is a traceable exposure profile including contractual rights and practical constraints on exercising them.

04 Evidence Threshold. Decide ex ante what minimum evidence would justify the contemplated exposure, giving special attention to behavioural validity, independence, timing, contradictory observations and scope of inference. Compare the marginal benefit of additional tests with their cost and delay. Output is a proportionate evidence requirement, with unresolved gaps and a conditional choice to proceed, test smaller, renegotiate or defer.

05 Exit Trigger. Record the specific indicator, numerical or qualitative threshold, observation period, monitoring owner, review cadence, legal termination right, residual obligations and fallback action that will activate revision. A trigger without authority or feasible execution is an aspiration, not an exit mechanism. Output is an operational response that links post-commitment evidence back to the original assumption and restarts review.

5. Two distinct layers of assessment

Layer A: Firm and market evidence. Public and authorised records can inform liquidity constraints, market signals, disclosed procurement activity, innovation grants, ownership, compliance obligations or company status. The task is to establish facts and their reliability at the relevant decision time, not to grade a firm's overall attractiveness.

Layer B: Commitment-specific reversibility. The entrepreneur supplies the contemplated action and often non-public commercial terms. An evidence engine checks claim relevance, while a commitment engine identifies costs of reversal, legal restrictions, implementation dependencies and feasible alternatives. A company number is an optional lookup key, never the object of assessment.

The five *Canvas steps* are workflow stages. The five *candidate evaluation dimensions* are separate analytic constructs: Evidence-Claim Fit, Commercial Viability, Reversibility Exposure, Strategic Optionality and Exit Executability. Neither set should be substituted for the other.

6. Candidate weighting and its epistemic status

An illustrative candidate Commitment Readiness Index currently assigns 25% to Evidence-Claim Fit, 25% to Commercial Viability, 20% to Reversibility Exposure, 15% to Strategic Optionality and 15% to Exit Executability. These are **scenario and interface demonstration parameters only**. Theoretical and empirical literatures justify considering the constructs; they do not identify these precise percentages. Even a large company registry cannot supply decision-event labels, ex ante contractual constraints and subsequent outcomes without additional linkage and coding.

A publishable model must make at least three distinctions. Empirical importance refers to predictive contribution for a declared outcome and population; normative decision importance refers to explicit, deliberated value trade-offs; and legal or safety constraints may act as vetoes independently of either. An analyst cannot convert feature importance in a model of firm survival into a universal normative weight for an entrepreneur’s contractual decision. Where critical data are unavailable, the relevant dimension should be ‘Not assessable’ with coverage information, not zero. The HM Treasury Green Book 2026 distinguishes structured multi-criteria decision analysis (including swing weighting) from arbitrary simple scoring; the OECD/JRC composite-indicator handbook requires uncertainty and sensitivity analysis of weighting, aggregation and missingness choices.

7. What UK evidence presently supports

In the user’s local Stage 2 audit (2 November 2026), 5,851,547 distinct Companies House identifiers were constructed from the input snapshots. The analysis indexed 29,253 financial document filenames and found 234,570 procurement supplier associations matching the company table by verified identifier, involving 48,244 distinct companies. It also parsed 810,721 OCDS release/compiled-record rows. Those values represent an important *identity-linkage foundation*, not 234,570 independent commitment episodes. A subsequent audit identified 15 more ZIP inputs but did not complete their content ingestion. Financial amounts, actual contract terms, decision-date evidence sets, five-dimensional calibrated weights and decision utility are not yet established. All numerical claims must be cited to the accompanying audit ZIPs and versioned before further publication.

Public company and procurement data sample the observable institutional environment rather than a firm’s private inventory, customer funnel, HR files or supplier contracts. A future platform may ingest company-authorised private documents through appropriately scoped connectors, with privacy, rights and validation controls. An LLM, where integrated, would propose candidate fact extractions linked to original source spans and require human verification for high-stakes clauses; it cannot certify unverifiable business claims.

8. Contribution and falsifiability

Problem contribution. Identifies the mismatch between evidence adequacy and the reversibility of the *particular* action under consideration.

Design contribution. Proposes a five-stage, revisitable link between a bounded commitment, its critical claim, exposure, evidentiary condition and executable exit signal.

Method contribution. Specifies provenance and time restrictions, non-compensatory gates, unknown-information states, optional weights and comparison of revised commitments under the same claim.

Practical contribution. Provides a research prototype that records and compares commitment scenarios, while clearly distinguishing algorithm demonstrations from validated recommendations.

Evaluation contribution, to be established. The hypothesised improvement concerns calibration of evidence search to consequence severity, detection of hidden lock-in, ability to redesign an action and quality of executable exit conditions. A demonstration that the code runs cannot establish a behavioural advantage over other tools.

9. Scope and boundary conditions

The design should initially be evaluated on discrete commercial commitments for which an identifiable decision date, critical assumption, exposure architecture and subsequent outcome can be reconstructed. It may perform poorly with irreversible public harms, collective decisions without a single authorised exit actor, highly path-dependent technological platforms, or ambiguous rules for estimating exit costs. Such cases should be studied as failures or boundary conditions, not hidden in a universal score.

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PART 02 / MODEL AND CALIBRATION

Commitment Readiness Assessment: model specification

Research state: All numeric weights are illustrative and uncalibrated. This specification establishes pre-commitment measurement and validation rules, not an already validated investment or compliance recommendation.

What is being scored?

The observation unit is a **venture-commitment episode**: company identifier (if available) + bounded proposed action + decision date + critical assumption + rights and resources at risk. Firm-level data only enrich the record. One firm can contain multiple episodes with different assessments.

Five candidate dimensions (distinct from Canvas steps)

Dimension	Illustrative weight	Measured object	Candidate observable indicators	Main failure mode
Evidence–Claim Fit	25%	Whether specific evidence supports the action's decisive proposition	Direct purchase behaviour; sample relevance; timing; independence; disconfirmation	Evidence on one segment projected to another
Commercial Viability	25%	Resource and cash feasibility for contemplated undertaking	Available liquidity; capacity; verified customer payments; due obligations	Strong interest but inadequate cash or delivery capacity
Reversibility Exposure	20%	Loss and lock-in if assumption fails	Irrecoverable spend; exclusivity; minimum orders; time; specific assets; third-party harm	A small pilot treated as equivalent to long-term commitment
Strategic Optionality	15%	Feasible alternatives preserved and cost of delay	Staging; non-exclusivity; switchable partners; waiting cost; alternative deployment	Retaining options at excessive cost, or premature lock-in
Exit Executability	15%	Actual ability to respond to contrary evidence	Termination rights; trigger observability; notice periods; penalties; residual duties	Exit trigger written but not legally or operationally executable

These five fields are assessment constructs with candidate operational definitions. Their names and indicators are subject to construct-validity testing; high score should consistently mean *more readiness* after reversing adverse raw variables such as exposure.

Minimal source record schema

Every observed fact must retain: `source_id`, `source_url_or_file`, `publisher`, `license`, `company_number`, `business_event_id`, `document_date`, `first_available_date`, `date_ingested`, `quotation_or_location`, `raw_value`, `unit`, `derived_value`, `transformation_rule`, `quality_status`, `reviewer`, and `record_version`.

`first_available_date <= decision_date` is mandatory for predictive use. Later evidence is held only in outcome columns. Plausible company-name matches are review candidates; they are not confirmed identity links. An unknown variable is explicitly `not_assessable`, never silently zero.

Two different meanings of weights

Empirical contribution weights

Choose an outcome **before** estimating importance, such as externally verifiable adverse contractual outcomes at 12 or 24 months. Compare an event-level baseline using finance and sector information with a model that adds ex ante commitment and exit measures. Estimate grouped out-of-sample predictive contribution of each dimension under temporal split validation. If positive contributions are normalised for presentation, label them *outcome-, sample- and model-specific predictive contributions*. Correlated features, differing observation rates and outcome definition changes require sensitivity tests. These percentages do **not** measure causal effects or moral importance.

Decision-value weights

Declare evaluation objectives and compare anchored performance swings, such as preventing £50,000 irrecoverable exposure versus retaining an objectively viable alternative partner. Use a documented expert and stakeholder elicitation procedure (e.g. structured swing weighting), record disagreements, and test different venture stages and decision types. This yields a transparent normative model conditional on declared trade-offs, not a universally true value vector.

Hard constraints

Apply non-compensatory gates **before** any arithmetic. Examples include an absent essential licence, an action involving unacceptable third-party harm, or a contract without authority to undertake the obligation. Display `BLOCK / RE-DESIGN / LEGAL REVIEW`, not an artificially high readiness score because of unrelated market evidence. The actual legal judgment is external to the prototype and needs qualified review where appropriate.

Composite index as a *candidate* secondary display

For comparable, fully assessable episodes within a pre-declared context, a possible descriptive index is:

CRI(candidate) = SUM_j w_j * s_j, with SUM_j w_j = 1 and 0 <= s_j <= 100.

This is a **display convention**, not an already validated probability of success. If any required dimension is missing, gate conditions are indeterminate, or the assessed constructs do not share a defendable aggregation scale, withhold the single index and display a partial profile instead. One strong dimension must not cancel a non-compensatory failure.

Evidence threshold rule

A useful implementation should avoid an unsupported claim that evidence strength and reversibility are both perfectly observed cardinal variables. Instead use a transparent decision protocol:

1. Specify the assumption whose failure would undermine the action.
2. Identify commitment modes: pilot, stage, buy, lease, exclusivity, guarantee, irreversible public launch, etc.
3. Evaluate severity, duration, contractual controllability and third-party consequences separately, with citations and unknown states.
4. Define minimum necessary directness and disconfirmation for this **particular** action; consider cost of information and delay.
5. Compare the current evidence with the pre-specified requirement.
6. If evidence falls short, test *two improvement routes*: acquire stronger evidence **or** reduce commitment magnitude/lock-in.
7. Record residual risk, responsible decision owner, gate status and executable exit trigger.

A high-impact decision with weak evidence is not necessarily doomed to deferral: staged terms might produce a defensible smaller decision.

Required analysis and benchmarking

- Missingness by data source, company age, sector, legal jurisdiction and firm status.
- Reproducible entity linking with false-match and missed-match audits.
- Independent coding agreement for critical assumption, exposure, exit rights and adverse outcome.
- Leave-one-dimension-out, alternative normalisations, equal weights, scenario weights, and weight uncertainty intervals.
- Compare finance-only, industry-only, equal-weight, five-dimensional and non-compensatory models.
- Temporal validation: information must exist at the date of the proposed action.
- Distinguish exercise of a successful early exit option from adverse breach or failure.
- Separate retrospective prediction, artefact correctness and real user behaviour.

What a report should and should not say

Allowed: ‘The current contract does not document a termination-for-convenience right. Review it before committing.’

Allowed: ‘Under the displayed illustrative assumptions, the 8-week non-exclusive pilot needs less pre-commitment evidence than a 24-month exclusive contract, because less money and market access are locked in.’

Not allowed: ‘This UK startup has a 78% probability of success’ unless a validated model, relevant outcome and calibrated probability actually exist.

Not allowed: ‘The AI has verified the customer’s demand’ merely because text was extracted from news, a pitch deck or a grant application.

Ready-to-build tests

1. With the same assumption and evidence, extending commitment duration and increasing non-cancellable spend cannot lower the required-evidence category without an explicit countervailing option-value rationale.
2. A non-compensatory gate failure blocks a positive recommendation irrespective of the candidate composite score.
3. Missing cash data reduce assessability and coverage; they are not treated as zero risk.
4. A pre-declared disconfirmation signal leads to an explicit contingent action with owner, authority and timing.
5. Two alternative contracts can be compared while holding company, claim and existing evidence constant.
6. No model can use facts first disclosed after the decision date as ex ante features.

Sources: See Academic Foundation and Contribution.md and the accompanying Source Catalogue.csv.

PART 03 / EVALUATION PROTOCOL

Evaluation programme and theory discrimination

Primary question

Does the Reversibility Canvas improve *evidence–commitment calibration* and executable reversal planning relative to existing assumption-mapping or experimentation templates, under identical information about the same proposed actions?

Competing explanations

- **Better attention, not specific theory:** Any longer checklist causes users to notice more risks. Equalise time and prompts in the comparison condition.
- **General risk aversion:** The Canvas discourages all actions. Test both low-exposure and high-exposure conditions; successful use should encourage inexpensive learning while slowing or restructuring high-exposure commitments.
- **Financial solvency only:** Cash-flow screening explains the outcome. Include a finance-only benchmark and vary contractual lock-in independently of cash position.
- **Legal information only:** Exit clauses alone explain differences. Compare identical contracts with varied evidence quality and identical evidence with varied termination clauses.
- **After-the-fact explanation:** The framework makes historical stories sound coherent without improving ex ante decisions. Conduct prospectively registered studies using only information available at t0.

Phase 1. Data and annotation validity

Construct 100-200 *candidate* UK commitment episodes as an initial target (not a completed sample). Two independent coders annotate claim, exposure type, available evidence, termination rights, dates and outcome categories; adjudicate disagreements using a codebook, preserve document sections, and publish a transparent coverage table. Pilot different types of commitments, including failures and non-failures. Report unidentified contracts and excluded cases, rather than silently dropping hard cases.

Phase 2. Model validity

Use temporal splits and industry/stage stratification. Predict a precisely defined outcome with (A) finance / stage only, (B) generic evidence quality, (C) equal-weight candidate five-dimensional features, (D) calibrated five-dimensional features, and (E) the proposed workflow plus non-compensatory gates. Pre-

specify discrimination and calibration metrics if predicting probability; do not confuse post-hoc class separation with causal tool benefit. Perturb weights, missingness assumptions, legal interpretation and adverse-event coding. Publish the distribution of decision changes, not merely a model AUC.

Phase 3. Decision utility

Design: randomised, counterbalanced scenario study using venture founders or entrepreneurship programme participants, with the same sources and one of two interfaces: current best-practice assumption/experiment template versus Reversibility Canvas. Present a 2x2 factorial design crossing *evidence strength* (weak/strong) and *reversal cost* (low/high), and vary legally executable exit rights in selected scenarios.

Pre-specified primary outcome: evidence–commitment calibration, assessed against an expert-adjudicated decision-specific reference rubric that considers both under-testing high-exposure actions and over-testing cheap experiments. Keep the expert rubric independent of the Canvas designers as far as feasible.

Secondary outcomes: correctly identified evidence gaps, false-positive commitment recommendations, unjustified deferral of low-risk experiments, viable staged alternatives generated, accuracy and feasibility of exit triggers, task completion time, clarity, inter-judge agreement and cognitive load.

Failure criteria: the Canvas performs no better than comparator after controlling for extra time; it systematically suppresses low-risk experimentation; it induces false confidence from arbitrary weights; users cannot act on suggested exits; or its advantage disappears outside contract-heavy settings. Report adverse findings alongside successes.

Phase 4. Field study

Follow live decision episodes in UK entrepreneurship programmes or collaborating ventures. Capture baseline evidence, company-approved contracts, versions of the Canvas, actual actions and review dates. Check whether pre-committed exit triggers are exercised or strategically reinterpreted. This is not yet undertaken.

Strongest theory test

Hold *assumption and evidence constant*, change only the reversible structure of commitment. The tool predicts a systematic change in proportionate evidence requirement and in the value of staging or renegotiating. This is more distinctive than merely observing that careful founders perform well.

Claims ladder

1. **Prototype mechanics work:** supported by code tests and a browser demonstration, if independently checked.
2. **Construct coding is reliable:** requires independent agreement on real cases.

3. **Model predicts defined outcomes:** requires correctly timed company-event data and out-of-sample tests.
4. **Users make better decisions:** requires comparative experimentation or field evidence.
5. **Ventures perform better long term:** requires stronger design and long follow-up, not currently supportable.

Stage and reporting status

The present documentation establishes a prospective evaluation protocol. No claims of improved entrepreneur outcomes, validated industry-specific percentages or causal effects are made.

PART 04 / WEBSITE COPY

Complete research website copy — The Reversibility Canvas

Use as site content, academic project page, programme description and GitHub docs. Do not interpret planned features as already deployed.

Navigation

Overview | The Canvas | Decision Logic | Evidence Model | UK Evidence | Compare Commitments | Research & Evaluation | Open Source Lab

1. Hero / Overview

Eyebrow: A design-science artefact for entrepreneurial decisions under uncertainty.

H1: The Reversibility Canvas

Subtitle: Calibrating Entrepreneurial Evidence to the Cost of Being Wrong

Lead paragraph: Every entrepreneurial action relies on assumptions, but not every mistake costs the same amount to undo. A six-week test and a two-year exclusive agreement can rest on equally uncertain market claims while exposing the venture to radically different financial, contractual and organisational consequences. The Reversibility Canvas makes that difference actionable. It links a specific decision to the claim on which it depends, the commitment created by acting, the evidence that could justify that exposure, and the signals that should activate a change of course.

Principle strip: The harder a commitment is to reverse, the stronger the evidence it should ordinarily require. Over-testing a cheap, reversible experiment can be equally wasteful.

Primary CTA: Start with a decision **Secondary CTA:** Explore the research framework

Epistemic label: Research prototype · candidate weights not empirically calibrated · public UK records used as evidence, not as a general company rating.

2. The problem / Why this tool?

H2: The missing link between evidence and commitment

Business-model tools help founders articulate hypotheses, map activities and design market tests. Their existence does not settle the more specific question of how much evidence is sufficient for the action being contemplated. Testing one customer response and signing a contract that cannot be unwound are

different decisions even where the underlying assumption is identical. A useful decision support tool must therefore connect evidence quality to the consequences of an incorrect commitment, and it must make cheaper, more reversible alternatives visible.

H3: Two errors, one design problem

Acting on weak evidence under substantial lock-in may create avoidable loss. Demanding exhaustive validation before a low-cost, reversible test may forfeit market learning and option value. The Canvas evaluates both risks together. Its objective is not to slow founders down; it is to align the burden of proof with the action's exposure and the value of acting now.

3. The Canvas / five stages

H2: One commitment, five linked judgements

01 · Decision. Define the actual action, owner, resources and duration. The unit of analysis is a particular commitment, not a company's generic quality. *Output: an unambiguous action statement.*

02 · Critical Assumption. Identify the proposition whose failure would make the action difficult to defend. Specify what would count as confirming or disconfirming evidence. *Output: a testable, time-bounded claim.*

03 · Reversibility Profile. Identify financial loss, elapsed time, contractual lock-in, organisational disruption, reputation, third-party exposure and reuse of assets. *Output: a differentiated exposure profile.*

04 · Evidence Threshold. Specify the evidence quality, directness, independence and recency proportional to that profile. Include cost of information, timing and potential to stage the decision. *Output: a conditional evidence requirement.*

05 · Exit Trigger. Specify the observable signal, responsible actor, review cadence, contractual authority and next-best action. *Output: an executable contingent response.*

Connector statement: Exit evidence is not the end of the process. If the trigger is reached, the decision, claim and exposure must be reviewed again.

4. Decision logic / What changes?

H2: Change the commitment, not only the evidence

When the evidence falls short of the proposed commitment, the most useful response is not always to collect more data. It may be to shorten a contract, remove exclusivity, purchase a smaller tranche, protect a termination right or run a bounded trial. These changes lower the consequence of error while preserving learning. The tool makes the trade-off explicit by evaluating *the same critical claim under alternative commitment structures*.

Four possible outputs: Proceed with monitoring · Test smaller · Renegotiate commitment · Defer pending evidence or authorisation.

Gate rule: An absent mandatory licence or unacceptable harm cannot be offset by good market traction. Such conditions require redesign or independent legal review before the scoring layer has any decision authority.

5. Model / What are weights for?

H2: A transparent assessment layer, not a universal success score

The research prototype explores five analytic dimensions: Evidence–Claim Fit, Commercial Viability, Reversibility Exposure, Strategic Optionality and Exit Executability. The candidate percentages 25/25/20/15/15 are visible hypotheses about a decision architecture, not empirical results. Formal weights require prospective objectives, temporally valid UK decision-event data, explicit value trade-offs, and sensitivity analysis across industries, stages and outcomes. Missing public information remains unknown rather than becoming zero risk.

H3: Predictive contribution and decision values answer different questions

A statistical model may find a dimension useful in predicting a narrowly defined adverse outcome; this does not automatically establish how much a founder should value it when choosing among legally permissible options. The platform records predictive evidence, deliberated decision values and hard constraints separately. Any future composite index must retain that separation and report how alternative weights affect conclusions.

6. Evidence / Why UK company data?

H2: Public evidence supports the decision; it does not replace it

The Reversibility Lab is designed to consult UK public registers and company-authorised records when they answer a question raised by the proposed commitment. Company identity, historical accounts, publicly disclosed procurement awards, innovation funding, ownership and insolvency records can constrain claims about capacity and obligations. They cannot reveal every private sales funnel, unfiled side agreement, employee condition or customer cohort. Each fact therefore carries its origin, available date, jurisdiction, transformation and review state.

Data status: The existing local Stage 2 audit constructed 5,851,547 distinct UK company IDs; it established 234,570 identifier-matched procurement supplier associations involving 48,244 different companies. That is evidence of a reproducible linkage process, not complete decision-level validation or a verified five-dimensional index. Fifteen further ZIP sources have undergone structural audit without full ingestion.

Provenance principle: Source record → dated fact → relevant claim → exposure/decision rule → reviewable recommendation.

7. Compare commitments / worked example

H2: The same claim can justify different actions

Suppose a venture has encouraging early interest in a new market but no independently verified repeat purchasing data. Option A is a six-week nonexclusive pilot with bounded spend and accessible cancellation. Option B is a 24-month exclusive distribution agreement with a substantial minimum purchase and narrow termination rights. Under the same evidence, the Canvas can regard the pilot as a reasonable way to learn while requiring stronger validation or renegotiated terms for the larger commitment. Both assessments depend on explicit assumptions; the example demonstrates the design mechanism and is not a report of observed field effects.

CTA: Compare two commitment structures

8. Open-source Lab / platform structure

H2: From a decision worksheet to a reviewable decision record

The research platform has four technical responsibilities. **Data ingestion** stores permitted source records, company IDs and dates without erasing provenance. **Evidence engine** maps observations to narrowly defined claims and flags contradictions or missing data. **Commitment engine** represents financial exposure, contract duration, exit rights and practical switch costs. **Decision studio** displays the five Canvas stages, proposed tests, scenario comparison, sensitivity analysis and a printable report. A future LLM module may suggest structured extracts from documents, with human verification and source spans for consequential facts.

Software disclaimer: The currently supplied offline prototype implements the decision-first workflow and demonstrative rules; it is not yet a live search service across the complete UK corpus, nor a validated automated legal adviser.

9. Research / how will we know it works?

H2: A tool must be evaluated for more than plausibility

The development programme separates data validity, model validity and decision utility. Data validity asks whether firms, documents and decision-time facts have been correctly linked and coded. Model validity examines construct overlap, candidate weights, missingness, out-of-sample benchmarks and legal gates. Decision utility requires founders using the Canvas to be compared with founders using established assumption and experimentation templates under identical information. The most distinctive test holds the claim and evidence constant while altering commitment reversibility, examining whether evidence demands and action redesign vary in the predicted direction.

Research integrity footer: A well-rendered worksheet or functioning algorithm is not evidence of improved entrepreneurial performance. Field and comparative evaluation remain research objectives.

10. Research contribution / footer paragraph

The Reversibility Canvas proposes a transferable design principle for entrepreneurship tools: evidence requirements should be calibrated to the exposure and available options created by a particular action. Its intended contribution lies in making that relationship explicit, revisable and auditable. The UK evidence infrastructure enables detailed historical and prospective testing, while the design itself remains open to falsification by alternative tools, adverse cases and boundary conditions.

Acknowledgement / citation: The Reversibility Canvas, research prototype, 2026. UK raw-source collection supplied by the project researcher: https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23873243 (DOI supplied by project; record and file-level licensing must be checked before public redistribution).

PART 05 / VISUAL IDENTITY

Olive & Oat — Visual Identity System

Brand: The Reversibility Canvas (research artefact). **Product:** Reversibility Lab (software and evidence infrastructure). Do not substitute one name for the other.

1. Purpose and tone

Editorial research design rather than SaaS sales dashboard. Calm, precise, auditable, mature, high-legibility, low-saturation, technically credible. The visual hierarchy must privilege the five-step *decision* workflow over company-search UI and avoid ornamental complexity that interferes with reading the Canvas.

2. Core palette

Role	Name	Hex	Use
Brand / ink	Dark Olive	#444D36	Main title, key bars, rule labels
Supporting	Soft Olive	#8A9673	Secondary emphasis, subtle markers
Surface	Sage Oat	#CED4B7	Gentle panels, stage separators
Warm accent	Oat Gold	#EBDEBA	Evidence Threshold focus, selected items
Page	Oat Paper	#F6F2E8	Site and poster background
Body ink	Almost Black	#242B20	Main readable body text
White surface	Soft White	#FFFEFB	Data inputs, editable spaces
Stroke	Warm Grey	#CCC8B8	Rules and outlines

Avoid fluorescent chartreuse, dark-green full-page fills, rainbow staging, generic “AI” neon and gradients. In dense documentation, use Dark Olive for ≤20% of the surface and Oat Paper/Soft White for the majority. Evidence Threshold uses the warm accent but must remain legible in monochrome.

3. Type system

Use **Georgia** for large, confident editorial headlines and short Canvas headers. Use **Arial / system sans-serif** for controls, body text, labels, numerals, charts and documentation. Fonts should be obtained from a recipient’s installed system; the source pack distributes no font binaries. Web scale: display 56–72 px

desktop / 36–42 px mobile, H2 36–42 px, H3 22–26 px, body 16–18 px at line-height 1.5–1.65, micro-label 11–12 px tracking 0.1em. Poster scale: 36–55 pt title, 13–18 pt module heading, 9–12 pt body depending on final A2/A3 size. Never reproduce an oversized hero title so large that it hides the actual Canvas.

4. Canvas composition

A single **landscape master sheet** is organised into five equal-height vertical stages with clear left-to-right connectors. Each header has a two-digit step number, title, guiding question, input fields and explicit output. Row 1: central research question and principle; Row 2: 01–05 Canvas with fields; Row 3: five analytic dimensions and their provisional status; Row 4: decision branches, validation states and monitored feedback loop. Place theory and dataset provenance in a companion figure rather than cramming unreadable full academic paragraphs into every stage.

5. Visual grammar

- A **solid arrow** means a required process dependency.
- A **loop-back arrow** means a monitoring feedback and reassessment event.
- A **dotted border** means a candidate, unvalidated or future module.
- A **solid-bordered panel** means a defined current artefact or verified input type.
- **Warm gold** highlights the Evidence Threshold judgment; **olive green** denotes normal process, never a pass/fail verdict.
- Use small explicit text status: `Observed`, `Derived`, `Not assessable`, `Needs review`, `Candidate`.
- Do not encode legal permission only through green/red colour; print the permission label and supporting reason.
- Icons are optional and should remain monochrome line icons with consistent optical weight. Do not crowd each field with decor.

6. Layout & accessibility

Desktop grid: max content width 1280 px, 12-column layout, 24–32 px gutters; cards use 1 px Warm Grey border with ~8 px radii. Mobile: stack workflow stages vertically while preserving numbers and sequence, with a sticky ‘Current commitment’ summary if needed. Keep colour contrast above WCAG AA for normal text. Provide visible focus states for keyboard input, 44 px minimum tap targets, descriptive field labels, live missing-information feedback, keyboard-accessible tabs and printable outlines.

7. Report visual hierarchy

A decision report begins with a commitment statement, not a company logo or composite score. Then show assumptions, evidence versus required threshold, exposure and reducible commitments, hard constraints, options to proceed/test/renegotiate/defer, exit trigger and provenance. An index (if eventually defensible) must be subordinate to traceable findings and clearly labeled with its calibration scope.

8. Graphs and charts

Use horizontal, label-rich small multiples for comparing two commitments; prefer absolute pounds, months, obligations and verifiable source confidence over unvalidated risk gauges. When showing alternative weights, display interval/rank reversal sensitivity instead of a theatrical ‘AI confidence’ percentage. Always supply date, population, definition, and method in a caption.

9. Prohibited representations

Do not depict 5.85 million *fully scored* firms, an operational UK-wide real-time intelligence engine, a trained LLM, empirically validated 25/25/20/15/15 weights, or a proven user-performance improvement. Existing matched supplier association rows are not independent decision episodes.

10. Design tokens and templates

The companion `Design Tokens.json` and `Olive and Oat.css` contain colour, spacing and typography variables. The supplied SVG diagrams are editable in Illustrator, Inkscape and other vector apps. For web production, update the static site HTML, keep textual evidence status visible and separate the decision studio from background source browsing.

PART 06 / EVIDENCE STATUS

Evidence Pack — read before republishing

Verified from the user's audit files, not from live database inspection

- Stage 2 report dated 2 November 2026: 5,851,547 distinct UK company IDs; 810,721 OCDS release/compiled records; 234,570 strictly ID-matched supplier associations across 48,244 companies; 29,253 financial file names indexed.
- Stage 2 processed 63 local files (5.33GB), including overlapping company source files; `company_rows_read` is not a count of distinct firms.
- Additional audit enumerated 15 ZIPs totalling about 2.94GB compressed, inspected ZIP member metadata/headers; it did not parse all records, perform Stage 3 linkage, or calibrate the model.
- The project-reported DOI `10.5281/zenodo.23873243` was provided by the researcher. The attempted live DOI inspection was not successful in the current tool environment. Do not claim its item-level size, licensing, or complete contents were independently checked here.

Reproducibility rules

1. Publish a machine-readable source manifest with each package's original source URL, retrieval date, SHA256, version, licence, jurisdiction and transformation history.
2. Source license governs reuse. A single Zenodo-wide CC BY licence does not create a new right to relicense incompatible third-party data. Where needed, publish metadata and scripts, not restricted raw contents.
3. Identify committed actions separately from firm records and procurement association rows.
4. Record when every fact was first available. Predictors at `t0` may not use later-filed facts.
5. Document deduplication and matching failures and public-vs-private coverage gaps.
6. Use explicit statuses Observed, Derived, Unobserved/Not assessable and Needs review.

File scope

This pack contains source **catalogues, citations, audit summaries and code specifications**, not the multi-GB dataset itself. No new raw UK company records were downloaded or privately accessed while creating this source pack.